



Kano City Walls

Impressive earthen fortifications of a city in northern Nigeria that have survived the ravages of time



△ MEDIEVAL STRUCTURE

Built to enclose the medieval city of Kano, the walls are a fine example of traditional West African mud architecture. Parts of the city walls have been adapted for modern uses such as housing.

The walls of the ancient city of Kano were built primarily for defense. They were begun by Kano's medieval ruler Gijimasu in around 1095 and extended in stages until the 16th century. Made of sun-baked red clay, the walls stretched for at least 11 miles (17km) around the city and are broadly triangular in cross-section. In places, the walls are more than 23 ft (7m) high and 30 ft (9m) thick at their base. They were pierced by 15 narrow gateways, with wooden gates strengthened by hammered iron strips.

Rapid expansion

The medieval city protected by Kano's walls was a bustling trading center. The Kurmi Market, which still exists alongside the walls today, lay at the southern end of trade routes across the Sahara Desert to the Mediterranean. In recent times, the growth of the city has far outstripped its origins. By the

21st century, Kano had become the second largest city in Nigeria and one of the world's most rapidly expanding urban areas.

With a population approaching 4 million by 2020, the modern city has engulfed its ancient walls in a wave of new development. Some of the gateways have been demolished to make way for modern roads, and other parts of the structure have fallen into disrepair. Yet, despite a chronic lack of funding, valiant attempts have been made to hold back this tide of destruction. Enough of the walls still remain to give an awesome impression of past glories and hold out hope for future preservation.

▷ MAINTAINING THE WALLS

Determined efforts are required to preserve and restore Kano's ancient walls. The mud-brick has to be resurfaced annually with fresh clay to protect against damage by heavy seasonal rainfall.

